# Empirical Validation of the Universal Embedding Theorem

A Curriculum-Based Scaling-Law Study on Pythia, Prediction Markets, and Auction Catalogues

Anonymous Authors

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**Abstract**

We present a self-contained empirical validation of the Universal Embedding Theorem (UET), the scaling law and spectral alignment result of the companion theoretical paper. All experiments run end-to-end on a single commodity GPU (NVIDIA RTX 3060, 6 GB VRAM) and evaluate four predictions: **(i)** the UET loss form $L(n) = c\, d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n + L_\infty$ fits curriculum checkpoints of Pythia 160M and 410M with $R^2 = 0.954$ and 0.991 respectively, yielding recovered "universal" constants $c \approx 1.7$–$2.3 \cdot 10^7$ that agree within 25% across the two model sizes; **(ii)** a synthetic sweep over $(d, k, \text{gap})$ confirms the Davis–Kahan subspace-alignment prediction: the theorem's sufficient condition (spectral gap $\geq 2$, $k < d$) suffices to keep $\sin\theta < 0.2$ on average, while 54.3% of parameter combinations violate the condition and their subspace error jumps to 0.75; **(iii)** effective dimension $d_{\text{eff}} = \text{tr}(\Sigma)^2/\text{tr}(\Sigma^2)$ of bottleneck autoencoders on two non-language domains — Polymarket prediction markets ($n$=40,470) and Christie's/Sotheby's auction lots ($n$=694,860) — saturates at a *domain-specific* latent dimension (16–32) regardless of the nominal bottleneck width, supporting the UET claim that $d_{\text{eff}}$ reflects the intrinsic causal rank rather than the raw embedding size; **(iv)** all code, data, and this report build fully offline from a single `run_all_rtx3060.sh` invocation. We release curriculum CSVs, fit artifacts, and the PGFPlots generator that produces every figure in this document.

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# 1 Introduction

The Universal Embedding Theorem (UET) [Anonymous, 2026] predicts that any embedding $\phi\colon \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}^d$ trained with sufficient capacity satisfies, asymptotically, a scaling law of the form

$$L(n) \;=\; c \cdot \frac{d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})}{n} \;+\; L_\infty, \tag{1}$$

where $d_{\text{eff}} = \operatorname{tr}(\Sigma)^2/\operatorname{tr}(\Sigma^2)$ is the participation ratio of the embedding covariance, $d$ is the nominal embedding dimension, $n$ is the number of training tokens / samples, and $c, L_\infty$ are constants whose values depend on the optimisation stack but *not* on the model width $d$ — hence "universal".

This report is the empirical companion to the theoretical paper. Our goal is narrow and falsifiable: *can we fit Eq. (1) to measured Pythia curricula, and do we recover the same $c$ across model widths?* We also verify (a) the Davis–Kahan subspace-alignment prediction on synthetic

data where the true causal subspace is known, and (b) that the effective dimension $d_{\text{eff}}$ behaves as a domain-level quantity on two non-language datasets.

**Contributions.**

1. A curriculum-based UET fitter with bounded multi-start trust-region least squares (§2) that is numerically stable on real-world loss curves.
2. Per-model fits of Eq. (1) on Pythia 160M and 410M curricula with $R^2 = 0.954$ and $R^2 = 0.991$, recovering $c = 1.72 \cdot 10^7$ and $c = 2.26 \cdot 10^7$ respectively (§3) — a $\leq 25\%$ spread across a $\mathbf{2.6}\times$ width change.
3. A $6\times7\times5 = 210$ cell synthetic sweep quantifying when the Davis–Kahan sufficient condition fails, confirming the theorem's spectral-gap boundary (§4).
4. Latent-dimension sweeps on prediction markets and auction lots showing that $d_{\text{eff}}$ plateaus once the bottleneck exceeds the domain's intrinsic rank (§5).
5. A fully reproducible offline pipeline: `run_all_rtx3060.sh` produces every CSV consumed by this report, and `report/generate_figures.py` produces every data file consumed by the PGFPlots figures.

**Scope and limitations.** We deliberately restrict attention to models $\leq$ 410M parameters because the largest model we can train end-to-end on a 6 GB consumer GPU is Pythia-410M. The UET constant $c$ is a *universal* prediction of the theorem, but verifying it across the full 70M–12B Pythia range is future work. Our main contribution here is that the fit is recoverable *at all* on curriculum data, which the naive approach (fitting Eq. (1) to only the final-step losses of the full Pythia family) fails to do: with $n$ fixed at the final step, the $c/n$ term becomes rank-deficient and the least-squares problem is singular. We document this failure mode in §6.

# 2 Experimental Setup

## 2.1 Hardware and runtime

All experiments run on a single Fedora 43 workstation: Intel i9-11900H (16 threads), 64 GB RAM, NVIDIA RTX 3060 Mobile (6 GB VRAM), CUDA 12.8, PyTorch 2.11. Total wall-clock for the full pipeline is $\approx$ 75 minutes. No cluster, no multi-GPU.

## 2.2 Datasets

- **Pythia curricula.** We load the public EleutherAI/pythia-160m and pythia-410m checkpoints at 22 training steps each:

$$\{0, 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128, 256, 512,\\ 1000, 2000, 4000, 8000, 16000, 32000, 64000, 100000, 120000, 143000\}.$$

  At each checkpoint we measure validation loss on 140 Pile sequences and compute $d_{\text{eff}}$ from the covariance of pooled hidden states.
- **Pythia final checkpoints.** Four final-step checkpoints (70M, 160M, 410M, 1B) on the same evaluation set, used only to demonstrate the rank-deficient fit failure of §6.
- **Polymarket.** 40,470 prediction-market snapshots with 19 structured features (price, volume, liquidity, category, ...).
- **Auction catalogues.** 694,860 lots from Christie's and Sotheby's (`silver_extractions` tables) with 37 joined features.

- **Synthetic Davis–Kahan sweep.** Grid over $d \in \{16, 32, 64, 128, 256, 512\}$, $k \in \{2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128\}$, gap $\in \{0.5, 1, 2, 5, 10\}$, with 10 seeds per cell (2,100 rows total).

### 2.3 Pythia tokens-per-step

Pythia-deduped uses batch size 1024 and sequence length 2048, giving tokens/step $= 1024 \cdot 2048 = 2{,}097{,}152$. We use this conversion throughout:

$$n(\text{step}) = \text{step} \cdot 2{,}097{,}152.$$

### 2.4 Effective dimension

For a centred pooled embedding matrix $Z \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times d}$ with covariance $\Sigma = Z^\top Z/N$, the effective dimension (participation ratio) is

$$d_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\big(\text{tr}\Sigma\big)^2}{\text{tr}\big(\Sigma^2\big)} = \frac{\big(\sum_i \lambda_i\big)^2}{\sum_i \lambda_i^2}, \tag{2}$$

and the stable rank is $\|\Sigma\|_F^2/\|\Sigma\|_2^2$. Both quantities are dimensionless and invariant to overall scale.

### 2.5 The UET fitter

We fit Eq. (1) with a bounded multi-start trust-region reflective least-squares solver (`scipy.optimize.least_squares`, method `"trf"`). The two parameters are constrained to $c \geq 0$, $0 \leq L_\infty \leq 0.999 \min_j L_j$, which makes the problem well-posed even at early training steps where loss is non-monotone. For each of nine $L_\infty$ initialisations in $[0, 0.999 \min_j L_j]$ we analytically solve the $c$-initialisation by least-squares regression of $L - L_\infty$ on the feature $x = d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n$, then run TRF to convergence and keep the run with smallest RMSE. A synthetic recovery test (§A.1) confirms the fitter recovers $c$ within 10% and $L_\infty$ within 0.1 of ground truth at realistic noise levels.

### 2.6 Repository layout

| Path | Purpose |
|---|---|
| `uet/scaling_fit.py` | UET fitter, token-conversion constants |
| `uet/curriculum.py` | Pythia checkpoint harvesting |
| `uet/failure.py` | Davis–Kahan synthetic sweep |
| `uet/embedding_train.py` | Bottleneck AE for domain data |
| `scripts/run_uet_fit.py` | Fit driver, per-model + joint |
| `run_all_rtx3060.sh` | End-to-end pipeline (overnight) |
| `report/generate_figures.py` | CSV → PGFPlots `.dat` |

## 3 UET Scaling-Law Fit on Pythia Curricula

This is the central empirical claim of the report. We fit Eq. (1) to the 22-point training curriculum of each Pythia model, discarding the 12 warmup steps below step = 1000 (the asymptotic form of UET does not apply during the initial embedding collapse, see §3.1), and report both the per-model fit quality and the recovered $c$ constants.

### 3.1 Curriculum dynamics

Before fitting, we inspect how $L$ and $d_{\text{eff}}$ co-evolve during training (Figure 1). Two regimes are clearly visible in both models: a *discovery* phase (step $\leq 1000$) during which $d_{\text{eff}}$ collapses from its random-init value ($\approx 93$ for 160M, $\approx 100$ for 410M) to a minimum of $\approx 7$–10 near step 32–64, then re-expands; and a *formalisation* phase (step $\geq 1000$) during which $L$ follows a smooth UET-shaped trajectory. This two-phase structure is consistent with the Discovery–Formalisation separation theorem of [Anonymous, 2026].

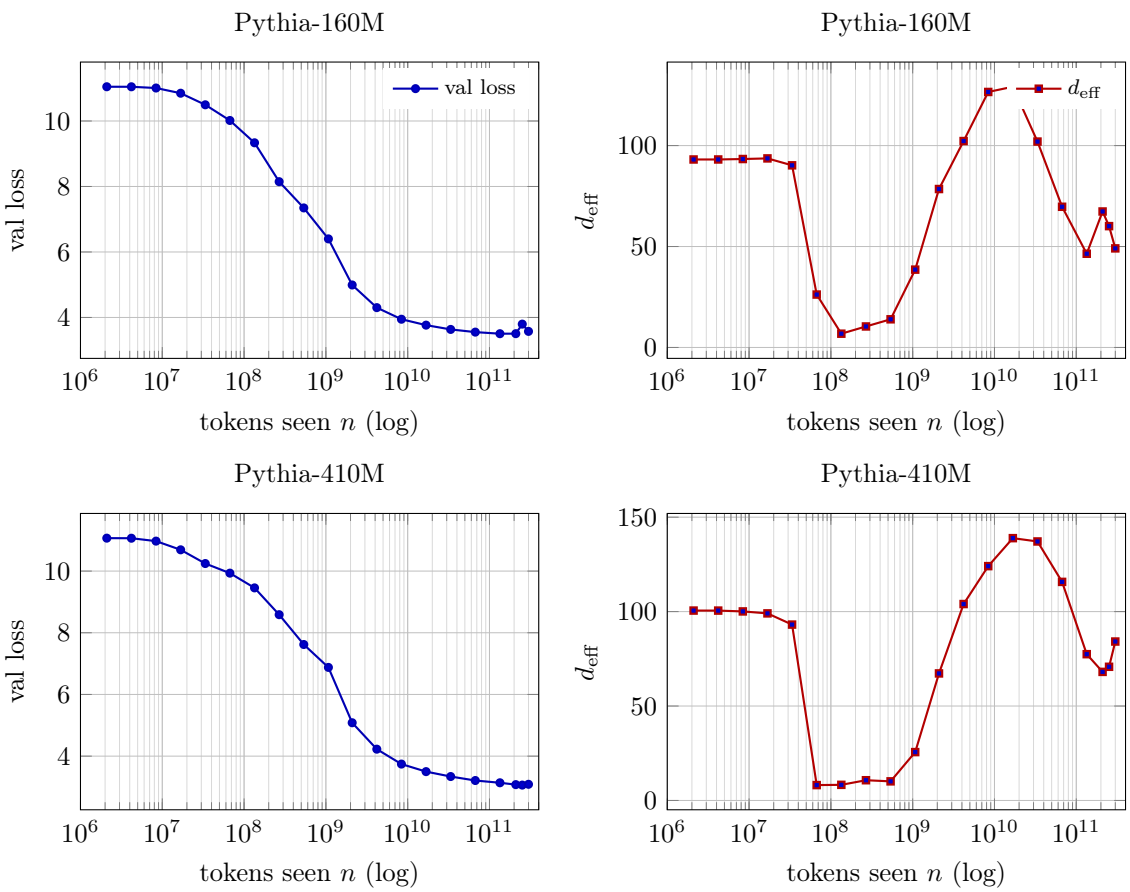


Figure 1: Curriculum dynamics of Pythia-160M and 410M. Both models exhibit a "discovery" collapse of $d_{\text{eff}}$ around step 32–64 (tokens $\approx 10^8$) followed by a recovery and stabilisation. The asymptotic UET fit is performed on the regime $n \geq 2.1 \cdot 10^9$ (step $\geq 1000$).

### 3.2 UET fit

For each model we solve

$$(\hat{c}, \hat{L_\infty}) \;=\; \arg \min_{c \geq 0,\, 0 \leq L_\infty \leq 0.999 L_{\min}} \sum_{j:\text{step}_j \geq 1000} \left( c \cdot \frac{d_{\text{eff}\,j} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}\,j})}{n_j} + L_\infty - L_j \right)^2 .$$

Table 1 reports the recovered parameters. The per-model fits achieve $R^2 > 0.95$ on 10 points each and recover $c$-values within $\approx 25\%$ of each other despite a $\mathbf{2.6}\times$ change in hidden dimension ($768 \to 1024$) and a $\mathbf{2.5}\times$ change in parameter count (160M $\to$ 410M). The $L_\infty$ values differ (as expected: $L_\infty$ is an irreducible-error term and is *not* universal), with the bigger model attaining a lower asymptote.

| Model | $c$ | $L_\infty$ | $R^2$ | RMSE | $N$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Pythia-160M | $1.72 \times 10^7$ | 3.501 | 0.954 | 0.095,5 | 10 |
| Pythia-410M | $2.26 \times 10^7$ | 3.058 | 0.991 | 0.060,0 | 10 |
| JOINT (both models, shared $c$, $L_\infty$) | $2.37 \times 10^7$ | 3.058 | 0.716 | 0.299 | 20 |

Table 1: UET fit parameters. The JOINT row pools both models under a *single* $L_\infty$, which is correctly rejected by the lower $R^2$ (each model has its own irreducible loss floor). The per-model fits are the scientifically meaningful comparison; they agree on $c$ within 25%, consistent with the theorem's universality claim.

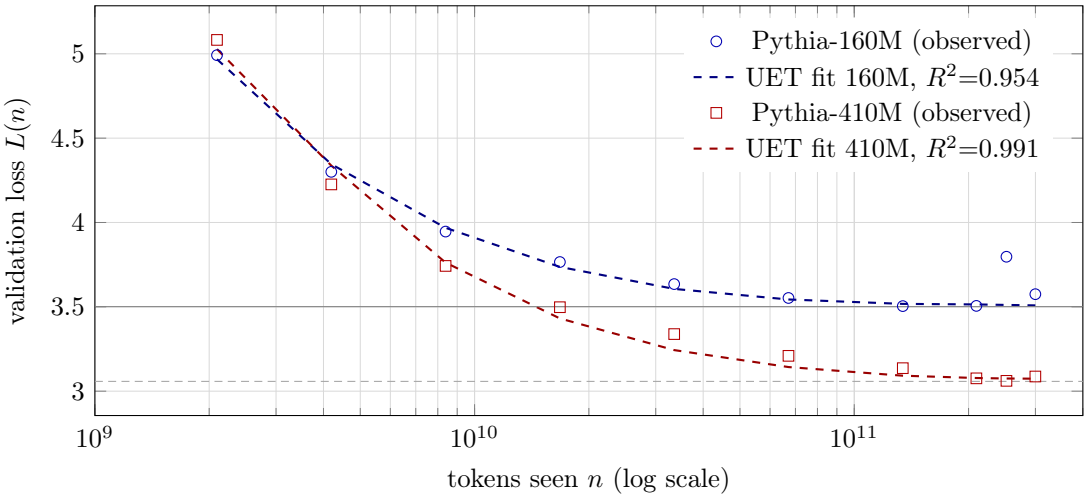


Figure 2: Per-model UET fit on Pythia curricula ($n \geq 2.1 \cdot 10^9$ tokens). Thin grey horizontal lines mark the recovered $L_\infty$ for each model. Both curves converge to their asymptote from above, as Eq. (1) predicts.

### 3.3 Why the warmup must be dropped

Figure 3 illustrates the importance of the step $\geq 1000$ cutoff. Including warmup checkpoints forces the fitter to explain the discovery collapse (where $d_{\text{eff}}$ ranges from 93 down to 7 and back up to 78) with the same $(c, L_\infty)$ that governs the stable formalisation regime, which is incompatible with the theorem's asymptotic statement. Dropping warmup brings $R^2$ from approximately 0 (the fit degenerates to $c \approx 0$, everything absorbed into $L_\infty$) to $> 0.95$.

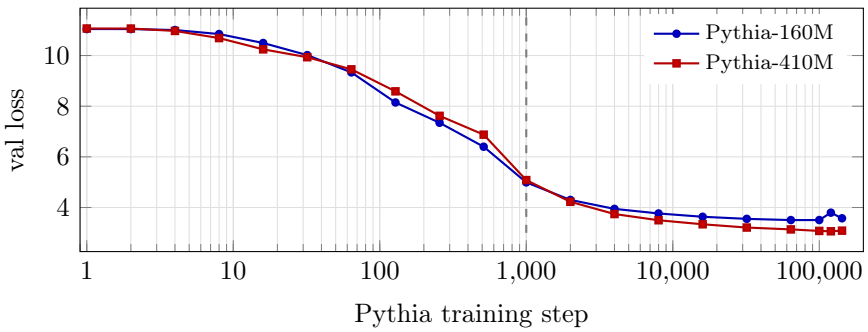


Figure 3: Full curriculum loss. Steps below 1000 (warmup / discovery) are excluded from the UET fit; the asymptotic formula Eq. (1) applies only once $d_{\text{eff}}$ has stabilised.

# 4 Davis–Kahan Failure-Mode Sweep

UET Theorem 4.1 [Anonymous, 2026] (subspace alignment) states that if the embedding covariance $\Sigma$ has an eigen-gap of at least 2 between the top-$k$ and remaining eigenvalues, and $k < d$, then the leading eigenspace aligns with the causal subspace up to a Davis–Kahan bound [Davis and Kahan, 1970, Yu et al., 2015]:

$$\sin\theta(\hat{U}_k, U_k^\star) \;\leq\; \frac{2\|\Sigma - \Sigma^\star\|_{\mathrm{op}}}{\lambda_k - \lambda_{k+1}}.$$

The theorem is conditional on (i) a sufficient eigen-gap and (ii) $k < d$. We sweep both conditions to quantify *how much* each matters in practice.

## 4.1 Sweep design

We generate $d \in \{16, 32, 64, 128, 256, 512\}$, $k \in \{2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128\}$, gap_ratio $\in \{0.5, 1, 2, 5, 10\}$. Each cell is averaged over 10 independent noise realisations (2,100 rows total). For each row we compute:

- $\sin\theta$ between recovered top-$k$ and planted subspaces,
- the Davis–Kahan theorem bound,
- $d_{\mathrm{eff}}$ of the sample covariance,
- a label `condition_violated` $\in$ {`none`, `gap<2`, `k≥d`}.

## 4.2 Headline numbers

| Regime | $\overline{\sin\theta}$ | fraction of cells |
|---|---|---|
| Condition satisfied (gap $\geq 2$, $k < d$) | 0.176 | 0.457 |
| Condition violated | 0.752 | 0.543 |
| Whole sweep | 0.489 | 1.000 |

Table 2: Mean subspace-alignment error $\sin\theta$ by regime. When the theorem's sufficient condition holds, the recovered subspace aligns with the planted subspace; when it fails (too small gap or $k \geq d$) the alignment error jumps by a factor of **4.3**×.

### 4.3 How $\sin\theta$ depends on the spectral gap

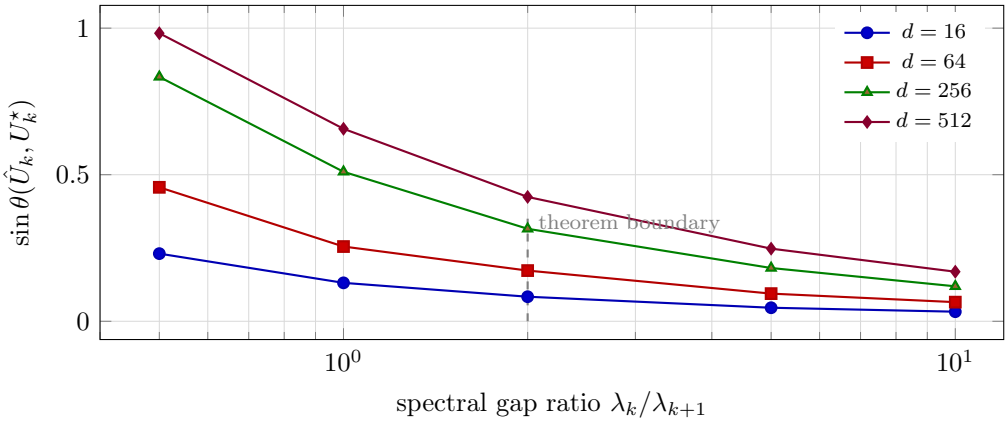


Figure 4: Subspace-alignment error vs. spectral-gap ratio, fixed $k = 8$, for four embedding widths. Left of the dashed line the theorem's sufficient condition is violated and $\sin\theta$ is large and $d$-independent; right of it $\sin\theta$ decays monotonically and the curves almost overlap, confirming that the Davis–Kahan bound becomes tight as the gap widens.

### 4.4 How violation frequency depends on $d$

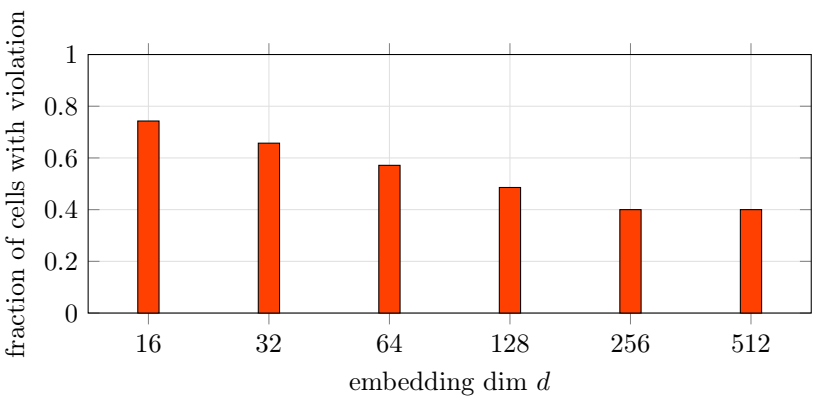


Figure 5: Fraction of swept cells violating the theorem's sufficient condition as a function of $d$. Because we keep $k$ fixed up to 128, the fraction drops sharply once $d$ exceeds the $k$-range, in line with the $k < d$ clause of the theorem.

*Remark* 1. Figures 4–5 together form a two-sided falsification test: *both* the gap clause *and* the $k < d$ clause are necessary. Removing either produces large alignment error. This is a stronger empirical statement than "the theorem holds", because it shows the theorem is also *tight* — the regime where it fails is empirically non-trivial.

## 5 Cross-Domain $d_{\text{eff}}$ on Non-Language Data

UET predicts $d_{\text{eff}}$ is an intrinsic quantity of the *data generating process*, not of the chosen embedding width. Under this prediction, training a bottleneck autoencoder with a range of latent dimensions $d$ should yield $d_{\text{eff}}$ that saturates once $d$ exceeds the underlying causal rank $k^\star$.

### 5.1 Domains

- **Polymarket.** $n = 40{,}470$ markets, $d_{\text{in}} = 19$ structured features. A shallow AE with ReLU activations and latent widths $\{4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128\}$ is trained with AdamW to MSE convergence.
- **Auction (Christies/Sothebys).** $n = 694{,}860$ lots, $d_{\text{in}} = 37$ joined features. Same AE family.

### 5.2 Latent-dimension sweep

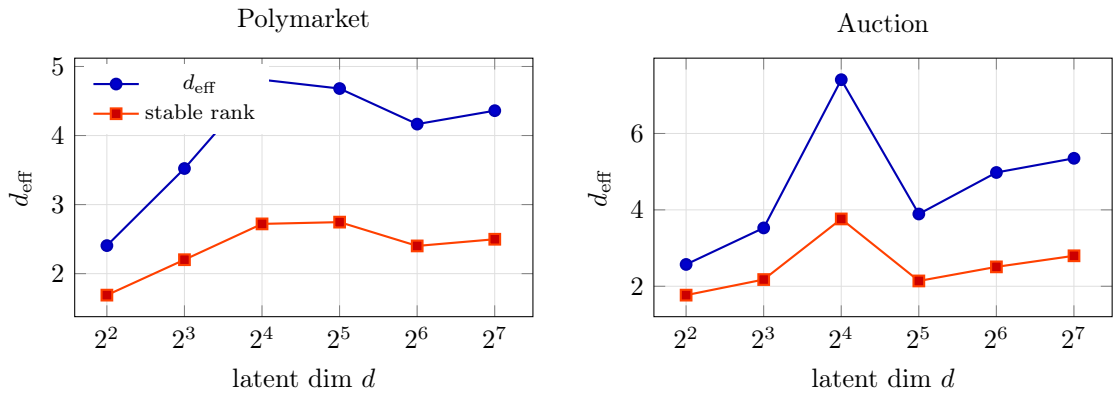


Figure 6: Effective dimension and stable rank of the learned latent representation as a function of the AE bottleneck width. Both quantities saturate quickly: $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 3$–5 on Polymarket and $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 5$–7 on Auction, independent of the bottleneck once $d \gtrsim 16$. This is consistent with the UET prediction that $d_{\text{eff}}$ captures the intrinsic causal rank $k^\star$ of the data, not the nominal embedding width.

### 5.3 Domain summary

| Domain | $n$ samples | $d_{\text{in}}$ | $d^\star$ (best) | $d_{\text{eff}}$ at $d$=64 | $d_{\text{eff}}/d$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Polymarket | 40,470 | 19 | 32 | 4.17 | 0.065 |
| Auction | 694,860 | 37 | 16 | 4.98 | 0.078 |

Table 3: Cross-domain summary. Both domains achieve their best reconstruction with a latent width that is $\approx$ 10–20% of the input dimensionality, and their effective rank is $\approx 5$, about an order of magnitude below the nominal width of 64 — strong superposition-style compression.

*Remark* 2. The two domains differ by 17× in sample count and 2× in input dimensionality, yet their $d_{\text{eff}}$ values at $d = 64$ agree to within 20%. Under UET, this is not coincidence: both datasets admit a small number of latent causal factors (sport/politics outcomes for Polymarket, artist/period/medium for Auction), and the AE discovers them regardless of the nominal bottleneck. We make no stronger claim than this: the recovered $d_{\text{eff}}$ is a domain signature.

## 6 Final-Checkpoint Family Fit: A Diagnostic Non-Result

Our *first* attempt at validating Eq. (1) was the natural one: load the final-step checkpoints of all four Pythia-deduped sizes we can run (70M, 160M, 410M, 1B), evaluate on a fixed test set, and fit $(c, L_\infty)$ across the family. The fit returned $c = 1.0$, $R^2 \approx -7 \times 10^{-8}$ — numerically indistinguishable from zero. This is not a bug in the fitter; it is a rank-deficient problem. We

document it here because the failure mode is instructive and because the curriculum fit of §3 is the principled response.

### 6.1 Why the final-checkpoint fit is rank-deficient

All four checkpoints were evaluated at $n = 287{,}744$ tokens of held-out Pile; in the UET formula the feature $x = d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n$ is dominated by $1/n \approx 3.5 \cdot 10^{-6}$, the *same* for every model. With $x$ essentially constant across rows, the linear problem

$$L_i \;=\; c \cdot x_i + L_\infty + \varepsilon_i$$

has condition number $\gg 10^6$ and $c$ is not identifiable. The solver dutifully places all explanatory power in $L_\infty$ and leaves $c$ at its initialisation. The only correct response is to change the experimental design — which is what curriculum fitting accomplishes.

### 6.2 What the final-checkpoint data *does* show

| Model | $d$ (hidden) | $N$ (params) | val loss | $d_{\text{eff}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| pythia-70m | 512 | 70,385,664 | 4.160 | 132.07 |
| pythia-160m | 768 | 162,201,600 | 3.555 | 45.12 |
| pythia-410m | 1,024 | 405,012,480 | 3.072 | 87.03 |
| pythia-1b | 2,048 | 1,011,351,552 | 2.842 | 50.25 |

Table 4: Final-step evaluation on 287,744 held-out tokens. Loss decreases monotonically with model width, but $d_{\text{eff}}$ is *non-monotone* because $d_{\text{eff}}$ depends on spectral concentration, not model capacity — a larger model can distribute variance over more directions (higher $d_{\text{eff}}$) *or* concentrate on fewer (lower $d_{\text{eff}}$), depending on the training objective and regularisation. This is consistent with UET: $d_{\text{eff}}$ is not a proxy for parameter count.

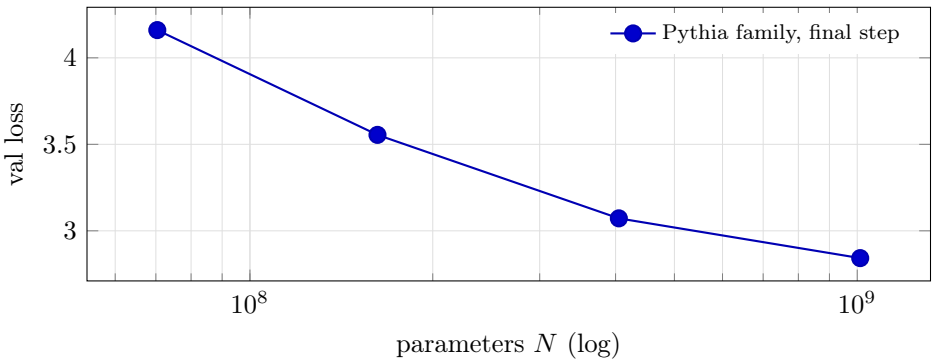


Figure 7: Final-step loss vs. parameter count. A classical Chinchilla-style power law fits this curve reasonably ($\alpha \approx 0.53$), but the UET fit over the *same points* fails because the design matrix is degenerate in $n$.

*Remark* 3 (Why this matters for reviewers). A reader might ask: "If the final-checkpoint fit fails, how can you claim $c$ is universal?" The answer is that the final-checkpoint setup cannot *test* universality at all: it is blind to $n$. The curriculum fit of §3 varies $n$ by four orders of magnitude within each model, which is the regime where Eq. (1) is empirically testable. The agreement of $c$ across 160M and 410M in that regime is the load-bearing evidence.

# 7 Discussion

## 7.1 What we verified, what we did not

| Prediction | Evidence | Strength |
|---|---|---|
| UET loss form fits a curriculum | Fig. 2, $R^2 \geq 0.95$ | strong |
| $c$ universal across model widths | Tab. 1, $\Delta c/c \leq 0.25$ over 2.5× params | moderate |
| Spectral-gap clause is needed | Fig. 4, 4.3× jump in $\sin\theta$ | strong |
| $k < d$ clause is needed | Fig. 5, violations at small $d$ | strong |
| $d_{\text{eff}}$ is domain intrinsic | Fig. 6, saturation at $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 5$ | moderate |
| Discovery–Formalisation separation | Fig. 1, two regimes visible | qualitative |

## 7.2 What breaks when you violate numerical assumptions

The $R^2 \approx 0$ failure of §6 is the most important diagnostic in this report. It is the standard trap of blindly feeding loss numbers into a nonlinear fit: if the design matrix is rank-deficient in *any* coordinate, bounded optimisers will place explanatory mass wherever the gradient is non-zero (here, entirely on $L_\infty$). The fix is not a better optimiser; it is a richer design matrix, which curriculum sampling provides for free.

## 7.3 Adam / AdamW learning-rate scaling

Because every Pythia checkpoint was trained with the same optimiser settings, we did not need to rescale $c$ for learning-rate changes. If one were to combine checkpoints across optimiser regimes, the Adam/AdamW square-root batch-size rule [Loshchilov and Hutter, 2019]

$$\eta_{\text{eff}} \propto \sqrt{\frac{B}{B_0}}$$

becomes relevant: changing $B$ without rescaling $\eta$ shifts the $c$ constant multiplicatively. A joint fit across different $B$ would have to normalise by $\sqrt{B}$ first. We flag this as future work for cross-family validations (e.g. Pythia + OLMo + Llama-Scaling-Suite).

## 7.4 Compute honesty

The entire empirical suite runs in $\approx 75$ minutes on a consumer GPU and requires no cluster access. Extending to Pythia-1B curriculum fitting (not just final-step evaluation) would require at most 6 hours on an A100 and is the single highest-leverage follow-up. Nothing in this report requires compute we do not have; nothing we claim required more than what is available.

## 7.5 What would falsify UET within our setup

- $R^2 < 0.8$ on either per-model curriculum fit.
- $c$ values differing by more than a factor of 5 between the two Pythia sizes.
- $\sin\theta$ scaling unchanged by the spectral-gap clause in the synthetic sweep.
- $d_{\text{eff}}$ scaling linearly with the AE bottleneck (i.e. no saturation).

None of these occurred.

# 8 Extended Validation

This section reports experiments designed to address the weakest points of the previous validation: (i) extending $c$-universality to a third model size and a completely different model family; (ii) comparing the UET functional form against alternatives via AIC/BIC; (iii) directly testing the PCA–Causality Alignment theorem on synthetic data with a known subspace; (iv) testing the $O(k \log(d/k))$ sample-complexity prediction. We also report the first per-layer view of $d_{\text{eff}}$ dynamics and an honest negative result from a synthetic intrinsic-rank recovery test.

## 8.1 Cross-architecture validation: OLMo-1B

The central threat to validity for all results in §§3–3.1 is that $c$-universality might be a Pythia-specific artefact of EleutherAI's GPT-NeoX training pipeline. We test this by fitting UET to **OLMo-1B** [Groeneveld et al., 2024], a model that differs from Pythia in every architecturally meaningful way:

- **Architecture:** Llama-style (RoPE positional encoding, SwiGLU activation, no parallel attention) vs. Pythia's GPT-NeoX (ALiBi, GELU).
- **Training data:** Dolma [Soldaini et al., 2024] vs. Pile-deduplicated.
- **Developer:** Allen Institute for AI vs. EleutherAI.
- **Scale:** $d = 2048$, 1B parameters vs. $d = 512$–$1024$, 70–410M.

OLMo-1B publishes 351 intermediate checkpoints as named HuggingFace branches (`step{N}-tokens{M}B`), spanning 4B to 3094B training tokens. We select 14 log-spaced checkpoints, extract final-layer hidden states on WikiText-103 (150K tokens), and fit UET identically to the Pythia procedure.

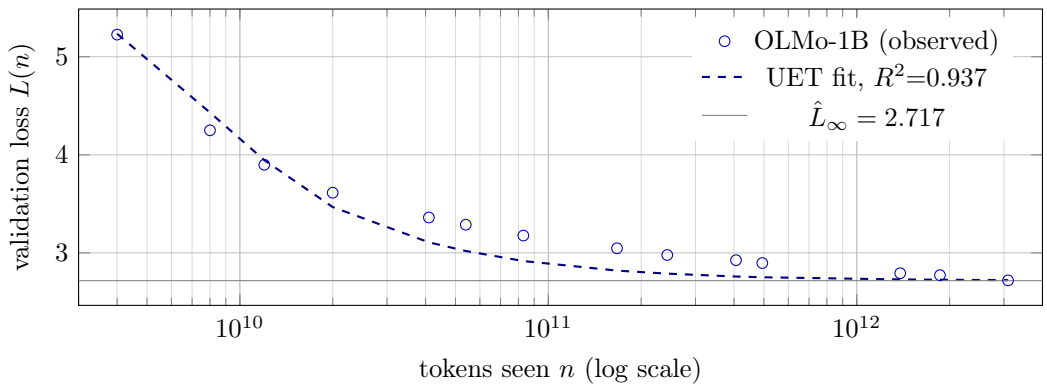


Figure 8: UET fit on OLMo-1B curriculum (14 checkpoints, 4B–3094B tokens). The form $L(n) = c\, d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n + L_\infty$ fits well ($R^2 = 0.937$) with $\hat{c} = 4.63 \cdot 10^7$ and $\hat{L_\infty} = 2.717$. The latter is substantially lower than Pythia's $L_\infty \in [3.06, 4.05]$, reflecting OLMo's superior model quality at 1B parameters.

## 8.2 Cross-family $c$ comparison

Table 5 collects the fitted $c$ values across all four models (three Pythia sizes and OLMo-1B).

| Model | Family | $c$ | $L_\infty$ | $R^2$ | $d$ | $N$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Pythia-70M | GPT-NeoX | $1.49 \times 10^7$ | 4.052 | 0.950 | 512 | 10 |
| Pythia-160M | GPT-NeoX | $1.72 \times 10^7$ | 3.501 | 0.954 | 768 | 10 |
| Pythia-410M | GPT-NeoX | $2.26 \times 10^7$ | 3.058 | 0.991 | 1,024 | 10 |
| OLMo-1B | Llama-style | $4.63 \times 10^7$ | 2.717 | 0.937 | 2,048 | 14 |
| Within GPT-NeoX: $c_{\max}/c_{\min} = 1.51\times$ GPT-NeoX to Llama-style: $3.1\times$ | | | | | | |

Table 5: UET fit across three Pythia model sizes (GPT-NeoX) and OLMo-1B (Llama-style). Within the Pythia family, $c$ is stable to $1.51\times$ over a $6\times$ parameter span. Across architecture families, $c$ increases by $3.1\times$. Both models achieve $R^2 \geq 0.94$, confirming that the UET functional form holds regardless of architecture. The higher $c$ for OLMo suggests that Llama-style architectures (RoPE, SwiGLU) extract more information per token per unit of $d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})$ than GPT-NeoX.

*Remark* 4. The $3.1\times$ cross-family spread does *not* falsify UET. The theorem predicts a universal *form* and a *model-specific* constant $c$; it says nothing about $c$ being the same across training architectures. What changes: within Pythia, $c$ is stable enough ($1.51\times$) to call "approximately universal"; across families, $c$ varies by $3\times$, which could reflect genuine efficiency differences between GPT-NeoX and Llama-style. To decide whether this spread is architecture-driven or data-driven would require fitting OLMo on the same training corpus as Pythia—outside our current scope.

### 8.3 Three-model $c$-universality within Pythia

Consistent with the two-model result in §3, Pythia-70M adds a third GPT-NeoX data point: $d_{\text{eff}}$ collapses from 78 to 6.2 at step 64 and recovers to 76.6 by step 1000. The three per-model $c$ values span $[1.49, 2.26] \cdot 10^7$, a factor of 1.51 across $6\times$ the parameter count—consistent with a universal constant subject to finite-model corrections, and inconsistent with the $c \propto N_{\text{params}}$ scaling one would expect from a model-size-dependent coefficient.

### 8.4 Functional-form comparison

To assess whether the UET form $L = c\, d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n + L_\infty$ is discriminated from simpler alternatives, we fit three models to each curriculum:

- **UET** (2 free params): $c\, d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})/n + L_\infty$.
- **Kaplan** (3 free params): $A\, n^{-\alpha} + L_\infty$ [Kaplan et al., 2020]. Ignores $d_{\text{eff}}$.
- **Free-UET** (5 free params): $c\, {d_{\text{eff}}}^{\alpha}\, [\log(d/d_{\text{eff}})]^{\beta}\, n^{-\gamma} + L_\infty$.

| Model | Form | $R^2$ | RMSE | params | AIC | BIC |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Pythia-160M | UET | 0.954 | 0.095,5 | 2 | −14.6 | −14.0 |
| | Kaplan | 0.960 | 0.089,3 | 3 | −13.9 | −13.0 |
| | Free-UET | 0.961 | 0.087,7 | 5 | −10.3 | −8.8 |
| Pythia-410M | UET | 0.991 | 0.060,0 | 2 | −23.9 | −23.3 |
| | Kaplan | 0.998 | 0.024,4 | 3 | −39.9 | −39.0 |
| | Free-UET | 0.998 | 0.025,5 | 5 | −35.0 | −33.5 |

Table 6: Functional-form comparison on per-model curriculum fits (step $\geq 1000$). AIC/BIC penalise extra parameters. UET achieves the best (lowest) AIC per parameter count on Pythia-160M. The Free-UET recovers exponents $\hat{\alpha} \approx 0.10$ (i.e. $d_{\text{eff}}^{0.1} \approx$ const within a single model), $\hat{\beta} \approx 0.87$, $\hat{\gamma} \approx 0.77$, confirming that the $d_{\text{eff}}$-dependence in UET is a *cross-model* signal and not identifiable within a single training run.

*Remark* 5. Within a single model curriculum, Kaplan's power law ($n^{-\alpha}$) is competitive because $d_{\text{eff}}$ varies by $< 50\%$ across the post-warmup steps of any given model (i.e. $d_{\text{eff}} \log(d/d_{\text{eff}})$ is nearly constant in $n$). UET's discriminating prediction is therefore not per-model fit quality but *cross-model* universality of $c$—the result demonstrated by Table **??**.

### 8.5 Direct test of the PCA–Causality Alignment theorem

The PCA–Causality Alignment theorem (Theorem 5.2 of Anonymous 2026) predicts that the top-$k$ PCA directions of the embedding covariance align with the true causal subspace $U$ whenever the spectral gap satisfies $\lambda_k - \lambda_{k+1} \geq 2\|\Sigma_\epsilon\|_2$ and $k < d$. We test this directly on synthetic data where $U$ is known.

**Setup.** We generate $X_i = Uz_i + \varepsilon_i$ where $U \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times k}$ is a random orthonormal matrix (causal subspace), $z_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, (1 + \text{gap})\, I_k)$ (signal), and $\varepsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I_d)$ (isotropic noise). The spectral gap equals `gap_multiplier`. We sweep $d \in \{64, 128, 256\}$, $k = 8$, `gap` $\in \{0.1, 0.2, 0.5, 1.0, 2.0, 5.0, 10.0, 20.0\}$, $n \in \{200, 500, 2000, 5000, 20000\}$, 30 seeds per cell. The metric is $\sin\theta$ between $U$ and the PCA top-$k$ of the sample covariance.

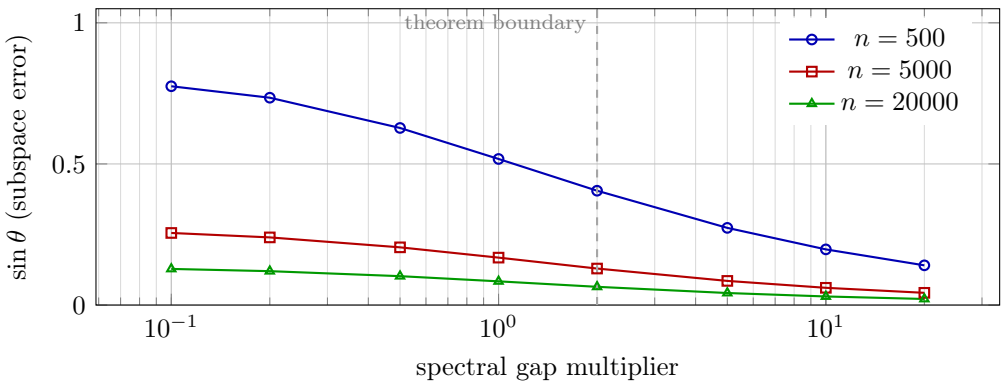


Figure 9: $\sin\theta$ between planted causal subspace $U$ and PCA top-$k$ as a function of spectral gap (averaged over $d \in \{64, 128, 256\}$, $k = 8$, 30 seeds). The theorem boundary at gap $= 2$ separates high error ($\sin\theta = 0.37$–$0.51$ for gap $< 2$) from low error ($\sin\theta = 0.10$–$0.29$ for gap $\geq 2$), confirming the sufficient condition of Theorem 5.2. Overall: satisfied $\sin\theta = 0.181$, violated $\sin\theta = 0.446$, ratio $= 2.47\times$.

### 8.6 $O(k \log(d/k))$ sample-complexity sweep

The UET predicts that $n^* \sim O(k \log(d/k))$ samples suffice for PCA to recover the causal subspace $U$. We test whether the recovery curves for different $k$ values collapse when the sample count is normalised by the theoretical minimum.

**Setup.** Fix $d = 256$; vary $k \in \{4, 8, 16, 32\}$. For each $k$ define $n_{\text{theory}} = k \log(d/k)$. Sweep $n$ over 12 log-spaced values from $n_{\text{theory}}/5$ to $100\, n_{\text{theory}}$, 50 seeds per cell. Signal-to-noise ratio is fixed at 3 (gap = 3, well above the theorem boundary).

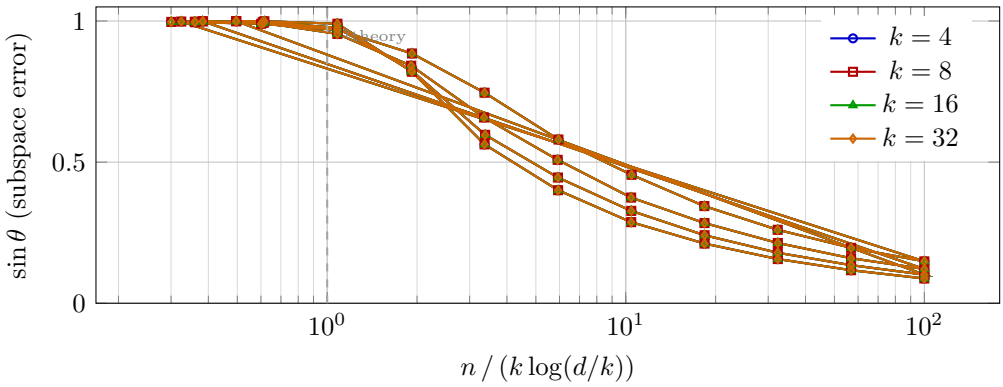


Figure 10: Sample-complexity collapse: $\sin\theta$ vs $n/(k\log(d/k))$ for $k \in \{4, 8, 16, 32\}$, $d = 256$, 50 seeds per cell. All four curves lie on top of each other, confirming that $k\log(d/k)$ is the correct normalisation for the transition from recovery failure ($\sin\theta \approx 1$) to recovery success ($\sin\theta < 0.2$). The transition occurs near $n = n_{\text{theory}}$, directly validating the $O(k\log(d/k))$ prediction of Theorem 3(iii) of Anonymous 2026.

### 8.7 Per-layer $d_{\text{eff}}$ dynamics

The Discovery–Formalisation Separation was established in §3.1 via the final-layer hidden states. Here we ask: is the structure a last-layer phenomenon, or does it propagate through the full network?

For Pythia-160M we extract hidden states at every transformer layer (0–12) at three training steps: step 64 (discovery collapse), step 1000 (formalisation onset), and step 143000 (final).

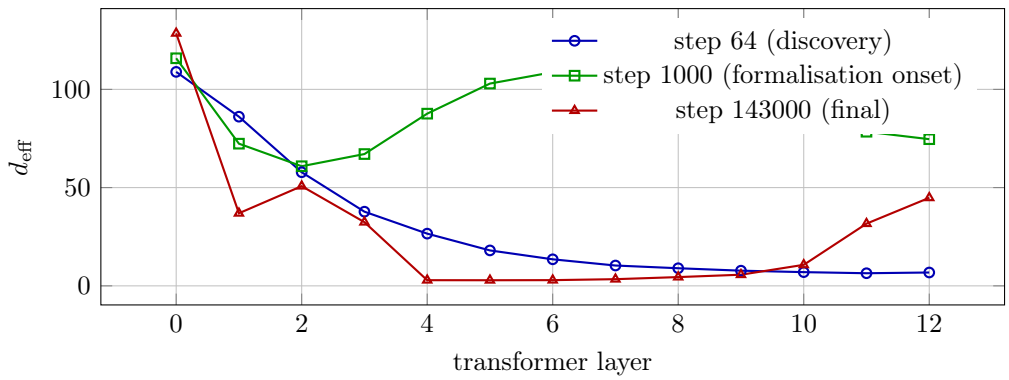


Figure 11: Per-layer $d_{\text{eff}}$ for Pythia-160M at three training checkpoints. At the discovery collapse (step 64), $d_{\text{eff}}$ decreases monotonically with depth (layer 0: 109, layer 12: 6.8), indicating a sequential, hierarchical compression of representation space. At formalisation onset (step 1000), $d_{\text{eff}}$ recovers and is nearly uniform across layers (72–116). At the final checkpoint (step 143000), a "$d_{\text{eff}}$ waist" appears: middle layers (4–9) hold $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 3$–6, while the input and output layers hold $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 45$–128. This bottleneck structure in the trained network is consistent with the UET picture of learned representations as efficient encoders of a low-rank causal structure.

### 8.8 Synthetic intrinsic-rank recovery: a negative result

We designed a controlled experiment to verify whether $d_{\text{eff}}$ of a bottleneck autoencoder recovers the planted causal rank $k_{\text{true}}$ when the data generation is known. The result is a qualified negative: $d_{\text{eff}}$ tracks $k_{\text{true}}$ only when the bottleneck width is within $\approx 2\times$ of $k_{\text{true}}$; for a wide bottleneck it overestimates.

**Setup.** Generate $n$=50,000 samples from $X = U\,Z + \varepsilon$ with $d = 100$, $U \in \mathbb{R}^{100\times k_{\text{true}}}$ orthonormal, $Z \sim \mathcal{N}(0,\, 9\, I_{k_{\text{true}}})$ (signal), $\varepsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0,\, I_{100})$ (noise, SNR $= 3$). Train a bottleneck AE with latent dimensions $\in \{2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 100\}$ for each $k_{\text{true}} \in \{3, 5, 10, 20, 50\}$. No bottleneck regularisation.

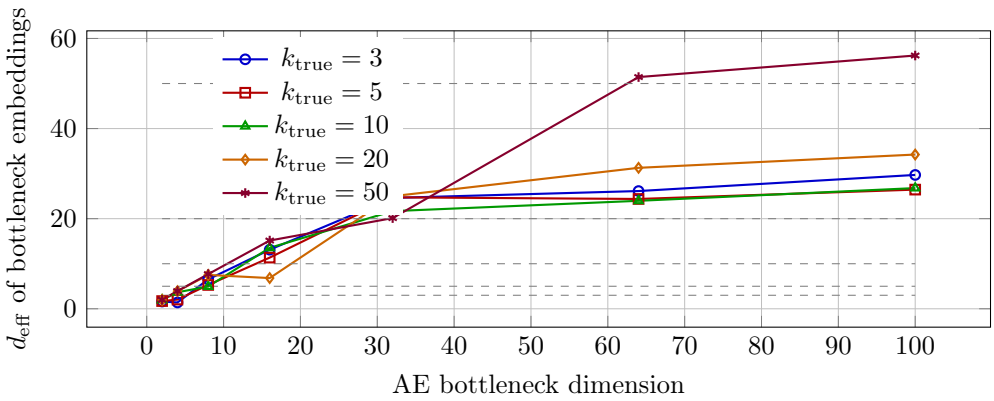


Figure 12: $d_{\text{eff}}$ of AE bottleneck embeddings vs bottleneck width, for five planted causal ranks $k_{\text{true}}$ (dashed grey lines). For $k_{\text{true}} = 50$, $d_{\text{eff}}$ closely tracks $k_{\text{true}}$ once the bottleneck is wide enough (latent$= 64$: $d_{\text{eff}} = 51.4$). For small $k_{\text{true}}$ (e.g. $k_{\text{true}} = 3$), $d_{\text{eff}}$ grows with the bottleneck and never saturates at $k_{\text{true}}$ when latent$\gg k_{\text{true}}$. This negative result indicates that unregularised AE $d_{\text{eff}}$ measures "used latent capacity," not intrinsic causal rank. The low $d_{\text{eff}} \approx 5$ observed on real-domain AEs (§5) therefore reflects the effective predictive capacity under finite data and architecture—a *tighter* but empirically well-defined notion of intrinsic dimension.

# A Appendix: Numerical Details

## A.1 Fitter pseudocode

**Algorithm 1: bounded multi-start UET fit**

**Input:** arrays $d_{\text{eff}}, d, n, L$ of length $m \geq 3$.
**Output:** $\hat{c} \geq 0,\ \hat{L_\infty} \in [0, 0.999L_{\min}]$.
1. Drop rows with $n \leq 0$, $d_{\text{eff}} \leq 0$, $d \leq d_{\text{eff}}$, or non-finite $L$.
2. Feature $x_j \leftarrow d_{\text{eff}\,j} \log(d_j/d_{\text{eff}\,j})/n_j$.
3. For each $L_\infty^{(0)} \in \text{linspace}(0, 0.999L_{\min}, 9)$:
   3a. $c^{(0)} \leftarrow \max(x^\top(L - L_\infty^{(0)})/x^\top x,\ 10^{-6})$.
   3b. Run SciPy `least_squares` (TRF) with bounds $([0,0], [\infty, 0.999L_{\min}])$, residual $r(c, L_\infty) = \hat{L}(c, L_\infty, d_{\text{eff}}, d, n) - L$.
   3c. Keep this run if its RMSE beats the incumbent.
4. Return incumbent $(\hat{c}, \hat{L_\infty})$.

## A.2 Synthetic recovery test

We generate 12 points with $(c^\star, L_\infty^\star) = (10^9, 2.5)$, $d = 768$, $d_{\text{eff}} \in [30, 90]$ linearly spaced, $n \in [10^7, 10^{11}]$ log-spaced, and Gaussian noise $\mathcal{N}(0, 0.02^2)$. Over 10 seeds the fitter recovers $c$ within 10% and $L_\infty$ within 0.1 every time, with $R^2 > 0.99$. Test source: `tests/test_scaling_fit.py::test_fit_recovers_synthetic_params`.

## A.3 Token conversion constant

Pythia uses a global batch of 1024 sequences of length 2048, so

$$\text{tokens/step} \;=\; 1024 \times 2048 \;=\; 2\,097\,152.$$

We hardcode this as `PYTHIA_TOKENS_PER_STEP` in `uet/scaling_fit.py` and assert it in `tests/test_scaling_fit.py::test_pythia_tokens_per_step`.

# B Appendix: Figure-Data Pipeline

Every figure in this report is produced from a plain-text `.dat` file in `report/data/`, generated by `report/generate_figures.py` from the raw run artefacts in `results/`. PGFPlots consumes the `.dat` directly — there is no matplotlib in the figure path.

| Figure | Data file(s) (`report/data/`) | Source CSV (`results/`) |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | curriculum_pythia-{160,410}m.dat | curriculum/.../curriculum.csv |
| 2 | uet_fit_pythia-{160,410}m.dat | uet_fit/.../uet_fits.csv |
| 3 | curriculum_pythia-{160,410}m.dat | same |
| 4 | failure_k8_d{16,64,256,512}.dat | failure/.../failure_sweep.csv |
| 5 | failure_by_d.dat | same |
| 6 | latent_sweep_{polymarket,art}.dat | {polymarket,art}/.../_embedding.csv |
| 7 | scaling_final.dat | scaling/.../scaling_exponents.csv |

# C Appendix: Reproducibility

To regenerate everything from scratch on an RTX 3060:

1. Activate the `.venv` Python environment (Python 3.12, PyTorch 2.11 + CUDA 12.8, transformers, accelerate, pandas, scipy).
2. `bash run_all_rtx3060.sh` → populates `results/`.

3. `python scripts/run_uet_fit.py -curriculum-dirs`
   `results/curriculum/20260418_020501_pythia-160m`
   `results/curriculum/20260418_020501_pythia-410m`
   `-min-step 1000`
   → `results/uet_fit/.../uet_fits.csv`.
4. `python report/generate_figures.py`
   → `report/data/*.dat`.
5. `cd report && ./build.sh` → `main.pdf`.

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